

THE COMPANION SERIES

The Strategy Companion

TURNING COMPETING OBJECTIVES INTO
DECISIONS YOU CAN DEFEND



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Purpose and Use

This Companion supports decision-making where legitimate objectives compete. It is for the moment when two good things pull against each other, somebody has to choose, and then has to hold the choice against people who would prefer a different one.

How This Companion Should Be Used

This document is decision support, not instruction. It is not:

- a checklist to be worked through mechanically,
- a method that produces a direction on its own,
- or a substitute for the judgement of the person accountable for the outcome.

Nothing here decides anything. It tests a direction that judgement has already produced, and it names what is missing when one has not been produced yet. The value lies in how it is interpreted and applied in context.

Contextual Assumptions

This Companion cannot determine what is appropriate. It assumes organisational context, leadership intent and operational reality have been considered first. Without those, no guidance of any quality produces a defensible outcome, and the reader remains accountable for what they decide with it.

On Strategy and Frameworks

Strategy here is not a plan, a roadmap or a list of initiatives. It is the deliberate articulation of intent that governs how decisions are made when legitimate objectives pull in different directions.

Where established strategic frameworks are referenced, they inform the reasoning rather than replace it. Where a framework and operational reality conflict, that tension is addressed explicitly rather than concealed behind process.

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Final Note

A decision without a basis is a decision somebody will have to make again.

This Companion exists to keep choices deliberate, explainable, and able to survive the person who made them.

1. Intent

Strategic decisions are hard for a reason that is rarely stated out loud.

The difficulty is not analytical. Most experienced people can tell a strategy from a list of initiatives, and can name the real tension in their organisation if asked privately. The knowledge is usually there and the choice still does not get made.

The reason is that exclusion is expensive for a named individual. Direction becomes real the moment something is ruled out, and the moment it is ruled out somebody loses budget, headcount, a product line they built, or the number their bonus is measured on. That person is in the room, usually senior, and usually right that it will hurt.

So the group produces a document in which everything remains a priority, everyone keeps their scope, and the decision is handed to the operating environment, which will make it eventually and badly.

1.1 Who This Companion Is For

It is for the person who has to choose, and for the person who advises them.

Those are different seats and the distinction carries weight throughout. An adviser owns the advice: the diagnosis, the named tension, the recommended direction, and an honest account of what each option costs. A risk owner accepts the residual consequence and is entitled to overrule the advice. A third seat, the permission holder, says whether the organisation may do the thing at all, and that seat frequently sits outside the organisation.

The method works from any of the three, with one adjustment. Where the decision-maker declines to exclude, that is recorded as an acceptance rather than argued away.

1.2 What This Companion Covers

Six things, in the order the work usually arrives in.

- What a decision basis is, and the three things it buys an organisation
- The eight conditions that separate a choice from a preference
- How the basis is built, and how the work is actually run
- The ten gates that test whether it will hold when challenged
- How the choice travels to people who were not in the room
- How the basis is kept, and how it erodes when nobody is watching

1.3 What It Deliberately Leaves Out

It does not assess deliverability. A direction can satisfy every condition here and still be politically impossible, which is a real failure and a different one.

It does not score. A strategy is not seventy per cent strategic.

And it does not generate direction. Asked for a strategy, the honest answer is to run the diagnosis and hand back what is missing.

1.4 Where It Comes From

The method was built in physical security work in the built environment, where competing objectives are unusually visible: a building has to be open and controlled at the same time, and somebody has to say which yields and when.

The logic is not security's. It applies wherever legitimate objectives compete, which is most places. One idea is borrowed from elsewhere and named where it appears: that confidence and durability are separate properties of a claim, which comes from intelligence analysis rather than from strategy.

2. Foundations

Before the method, the case for having one. A decision basis is the stated account of why this choice and not another. Everything in this Companion exists to build one, test one, or make one travel.

2.1 Why Strategic Decisions Are Difficult

Three difficulties sit underneath most stuck decisions, and only one of them is about information.

The first is that the objectives in tension are both legitimate. Growth against margin, speed against quality, openness against control, cost against resilience. Nobody is arguing for a bad thing, which is why the argument does not resolve itself.

The second is that the cost of choosing lands on a person rather than on the organisation in the abstract. An organisation cannot feel a loss. A director whose book shrinks can.

The third is that the decision is rarely urgent on the day it becomes necessary. There is almost always a reason to look at it again next quarter, and the reasons are usually good ones.

2.2 What a Decision Basis Does

Three things, and the first is the one most often missed.

It takes the person out of the loss

When the budget goes and there is a basis, the reason is the rationale. When the budget goes and there is no basis, the reason is whoever signed it.

Those two situations look identical on a spreadsheet and they are nothing alike to live through. The first produces disagreement, which an organisation survives. The second produces resentment, which it carries for years and pays for in ways nobody traces back to the meeting where it started.

It buys back the time

A settled question with a basis stays settled. The same issue arrives in March, the answer is already written and reasoned, and the meeting is ten minutes.

Without one, every decision is relitigated by whoever was not in the room the first time. An organisation can lose more capacity to re-deciding than to deciding, and almost nobody measures it.

It outlives the people who made it

The person who decided moves on. The basis does not.

A successor who inherits a constraint with its reasoning attached can judge whether it still applies. A successor who inherits a rule with no reasoning will either follow it superstitiously or drop it, and both are wrong for the same reason.

2.3 Two Kinds of Limit

Every decision of consequence runs into two constraints, and confusing them is how a strategic question quietly becomes a budget question.

Operational constraint is what is practically achievable. Cost, time, capability, infrastructure, people.

Legitimacy constraint is what is acceptable. Law, consent, ethics, public expectation, what the organisation can be seen doing and still recognise itself.

Inability and inadvisability are not the same condition. Something unaffordable this year may be sensible next year. Something the organisation should not do does not become sensible when the money arrives.

Collapsing the second into the first is how organisations talk themselves into decisions they later cannot defend. It rarely feels like a moral choice at the time. It feels like arithmetic.

2.4 Three Seats

Seat	Owns	Does not own
Adviser	The advice: diagnosis, tension, recommended direction, and what each option costs	The consequence. An adviser who softens a recommendation to make it acceptable has taken the risk without the authority
Risk owner	The residual consequence. Entitled to overrule the advice and carry exposure the adviser would not	Permission. They cannot grant themselves the right to act
Permission holder	Whether the organisation may do this at all. Often outside the organisation: a regulator, a licensing authority, a court, sometimes the people who live with the result	The decision itself. They set the edge, not the direction inside it

Two of these frequently sit in the same person, which is why they get run together. Naming them separately costs nothing and prevents the most expensive confusion in the set: an organisation acting as though necessity were permission.

3. The Model

Eight conditions. They are what separates a choice from a preference, and a basis from a justification written afterwards. Where they are absent, what you have may well be planning, analysis or design, none of which will hold when somebody senior asks why.

The conditions constrain reasoning, not procedure. They say nothing about how you get there. They say what has to be true when you arrive, and each one is a question you will eventually be asked out loud.

3.1 The Position

Strategy is the deliberate articulation of intent that governs how decisions are made when legitimate objectives pull in different directions.

A rough test, rough on purpose: if the thing on the page is a choice somebody could carry out without knowing why it was chosen, it sits downstream. Strategy is the reasoning that governs the choice, not the choice itself. A contract term, a location, a headcount, any of those can be the expression of a strategy and none of them is the strategy.

3.2 C1: Context Shapes the Strategy

The approach is fixed to the context it serves. A regional retailer, a hospital trust and a defence contractor are not the same problem at three intensities. They differ in what counts as the asset, who the opposition realistically is, and which consequence actually matters.

The test. Could this strategy be lifted into a different organisation and still read as sensible? If it could, context has done no work, and what you are holding is a set of platitudes with a logo on the front.

3.3 C2: Strategy Begins with Diagnosis

Say why the problem is hard here, in this organisation, under these constraints. If a competitor could write the same paragraph about themselves, nothing has been diagnosed.

A diagnosis that names only a market condition is almost always incomplete. The ones that work name the internal reason the obvious answer has not already been taken, which is usually where the real difficulty is hiding.

The test. Does the diagnosis explain why the obvious answer has not already been taken, and who would have to lose for it to be?

3.4 C3: Tension Must Be Explicit, and Correctly Classified

Strategy exists where legitimate objectives collide. If no structural tension is named, the work describes a condition rather than forming a direction. If optimisation looks possible across every objective at once, it has not started.

Naming it is half the job. The other half is saying what kind it is, which Section 5 sets out in full, because the four kinds want different treatment and forcing one into the shape of another is the most common structural error in strategy work.

The test. Is a tension named, and is its kind named?

3.5 C4: Direction Must Exclude

Strategy becomes visible at the moment something is ruled out. While every option stays open, nothing has been chosen. Guardrails are set by what will not be pursued, never by what is encouraged, because encouragement costs nothing and commits nobody.

The guardrails also have to work in someone else's hands. The people who meet the hard cases were not in the room, cannot ask what you meant, and will be under pressure when they need the rule. A rule only its author can apply is not a guardrail, it is a preference with a wide circulation.

The test. Is something ruled out, and can you name who loses by it? If nothing in the document costs anybody anything, nothing has been decided.

3.6 C5: Direction Must Be Permitted, Not Only Possible

C4 says what you will not do. This asks what you may not do, which is a different question with a different answer decided by a different person.

Necessity is settled inside the organisation. Permission is settled outside it, by law, by consent, by what the people affected will accept, and by commitments already made in public. The two get run together because both arrive as a no.

The test. Name who grants permission, then ask whether they would recognise the account you have given of what you are doing. Where the account given to them and the account given internally are two different accounts, permission is being managed rather than held.

3.7 C6: Tools Inform, They Do Not Decide

SWOT, PESTEL, scenario planning, risk models, maturity assessments, market analysis, benchmarking. Every one sharpens perception. Not one chooses a direction.

Where a tool produces the outcome before intent has been articulated, analysis has quietly replaced strategy. The symptom is a conclusion you could predict from the method alone, without reading a single finding.

The test. Did the direction come from judgement about the problem, or from whatever the analysis happened to produce?

3.8 C7: Strategy Must Survive Stress

If conditions tighten, budgets shrink, or a competitor moves first, does the governing logic still hold? Where the answer changes under pressure, what was written was a preference. A direction that only works in good conditions is a description of good conditions.

The test. State the single most uncomfortable offer the opposition could make, and check whether the direction survives it.

3.9 C8: Both Clocks Must Be Declared

Every direction carries two timings. They run in opposite directions and both get left out.

Durability is how long the direction can be expected to hold, and what would reopen it. A direction with no stated shelf life ages quietly inside a document that still looks authoritative.

The horizon is how long you have before the decision must be made, and it is set by whatever is moving against you rather than by the calendar. A date in the diary is a deadline and deadlines are comfortable because you control them.

The horizon is not an argument for haste. A decision taken fast on a misread situation is worse than a slow one, because it carries you further from where you should be before anybody notices.

Accuracy and timeliness are separate goods.

The test. Are both stated, and is the horizon set by something outside the organisation?

3.10 What the Eight Prevent

Between them they stop strategy decaying into a collection of initiatives, a compliance summary, a risk register written as prose, or a delivery plan in disguise. Each of those is a real document with a real job. None of them governs a decision.

4. The Workflow

Four layers, then eight moments. The layers say what order the questions come in. The moments say where you stand while you answer them.

4.1 The Four Layers

Layer	The question it answers
WHY	Why does this organisation or function exist, what is it weighed against, what level of ambition is appropriate, and what will it refuse?
WHAT	What conditions, competitors, capabilities, dependencies and credible scenarios must that intent address?
HOW	How is the intended position achieved, across people, process, technology and structure?
PROVE	Does the resulting arrangement achieve what the WHY layer said it should?

Then the return: what did the outcome show that the analysis did not, and what does that change about the intent?

4.2 The Loop

Decisions produce outcomes. Outcomes produce evidence. That evidence should sharpen the next decision rather than settling into a closed report nobody reopens.

Without the loop the method is a straight line ending in a document, and a document is a snapshot. With it, the method is a system that gets less wrong over time. That is a lower ambition than being right and a far more achievable one.

4.3 Four Ways the Order Gets Broken

Failure	What it looks like on the page
Starting at HOW	A specification with no stated reason for this choice rather than another
Skipping WHY	Thorough, competent analysis that cannot say what the organisation is trying to achieve
Treating PROVE as WHY	Using audit or test findings to generate intent, when they can only test intent that already exists
Collapsing WHY into WHAT	Naming conditions and calling it strategy, with no tension and no direction

The third is the subtle one. Findings from an audit, a penetration test or a market study arrive carrying the authority of evidence, and it is tempting to let them set direction. They cannot. They can only measure a direction against something, and where nothing has been stated they will be read as direction they were never built to carry.

4.4 How the Work Is Actually Run

The layers do not tell you how the work gets done, and a reader holding only the layers will book a workshop, which is the wrong instrument.

Who convenes it. The person who will accept the residual consequence. Not the strategy function, not a consultant. If that person will not convene it, you have your first finding and it is a significant one.

Who is in the room. Four to six people, and everyone present must be able to lose something. A room of people with nothing at stake produces a document nobody resists, which reads as consensus and is actually indifference.

How long it takes. Three sessions, not one away-day. Diagnosis, then tension and direction, then test. At least a week between them, because the gaps are where evidence gets fetched and where positions quietly change. A single workshop produces whatever the most confident person believed that morning.

What counts as evidence. Every load-bearing claim carries a confidence mark and a durability mark. Anything nobody can source is marked as an assumption and stays visibly marked, all the way into the final document. Assumptions are fine. Assumptions wearing the clothes of findings are not.

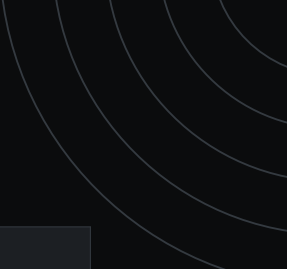
What happens to disagreement. Record it, do not average it. Where two people read the diagnosis differently, that goes into the written situation as a finding, because it will resurface under pressure and it is cheaper to have it on the page. Averaging two positions produces a third nobody holds and nobody will defend.

Who writes it. One person. Committee drafting produces balance, and balance is precisely what C4 forbids.

4.5 The Eight Moments

The layers are the order of the questions. The moments are the places in the work, each with a conversation attached. The full question sets are in Annexure C.

Moment	What happens
M1 Before you start	Establish that this is a strategic question, and name the three seats
M2 Diagnosis	Why is this hard here, and why has the obvious answer not been taken
M3 Tension and direction	Name the tension, classify it, choose, and rule something out
M4 The test	The ten gates, in order, on the draft as it stands
M5 The handover	The basis, on one page



Moment	What happens
M6 The order	Situation, mission, execution, administration, command
M7 The rehearsal	Break the plan on purpose before it goes live
M8 The review	What has been done that the strategy excluded, and who decided it

Use them in whatever order the work arrives in. You will rarely start at the beginning. A choice already made can be entered at M4, and a strategy somebody else wrote can be entered at M8.

5. Reading the Ground

Three instruments for seeing the problem accurately before deciding anything. They are not methods and they produce no output. They change what you notice.

5.1 The Four Kinds of Tension

Naming a tension is half the job. Saying what kind it is decides how it should be treated.

Kind	What it is	What it wants
Puzzle	A hard problem with an optimal solution	Analysis. Not a strategic question, though it often arrives dressed as one
Dilemma	Two possible answers, neither logically the better	A decision, taken knowing no analysis was going to settle it
Trade-off	Many possible answers, each striking a different balance between two competing pressures	A stated position on the range, and the reason for that position rather than a neighbouring one
Paradox	Two seemingly contradictory things both true at once, with no real solution	Reconciliation. Hold both, find an arrangement that works for now, and accept that it is temporary and needs tending

The classification is de Wit and Meyer's. The reading taken from it here is that forcing a paradox through a dilemma's logic produces a confident strategy that has discarded something the organisation cannot do without. Control against chaos is a paradox. So is deliberate planning against emergent practice.

On a paradox the exclusion is not one of the poles. It is the behaviours that would collapse the paradox into one pole, and those need naming with the same precision.

One qualification. Some tensions are settled outside the organisation before they ever reach you, by regulation, by a parent company, by a licence condition. Spotting a pre-resolved tension is a finding in its own right and stating it satisfies C3. Inventing a tension the environment has already settled does not.

5.2 Three Kinds of Claim

The WHAT layer gathers conditions, competitors, capabilities, dependencies and scenarios, and treats them as one body of evidence. They are three things with three different weights.

Description says what is. A count, a measurement, a clause in a contract. It can be checked, and if it is wrong somebody can show you.

Explanation says why. It is a theory about cause, and a good theory is still a theory.

Estimate says what comes next. It is a judgement, it is the weakest claim in the set, and it is almost always the one carrying the most weight in the room.

Assessments slide from the first to the third without marking the move. A count of incidents becomes a reason for them and then a forecast of more, and at no point did anybody announce that the ground had changed underneath the sentence. By the end it all reads as evidence.

Marking which is which costs a word per finding. It is the cheapest honesty available in the method.

5.3 Confidence and Durability

Two questions, and they do not move together.

Confidence asks how well founded a finding is. Durability asks how long it stays true. A competitor benchmark is high confidence and low durability: accurate the day it was taken, stale within a quarter. A named structural tension rests on judgement and may hold for a decade.

Declare only confidence and you quietly reward the past, because the past is the only thing that can be demonstrated. A framework that rewards the past produces rear-view decisions in a forward-looking organisation.

There is a related marking worth making on every finding: settled or unsettled. A settled finding has an answer that exists somewhere. An unsettled one does not, because it turns on a decision nobody has taken yet. Both belong in the basis. What they must not do is sit there looking identical, because a reader skimming for the confident sentence will take the settled one and build on it, and the unsettled one was the one that mattered.

5.4 Is There an Opponent?

Some environments contain something that adapts. A competitor, an adversary, a regulator under political pressure, a dominant customer, an activist investor. Anyone who watches what you choose and changes because of it.

Where that is true the problem will not sit still. Your measure changes the environment, the environment changes your measure, and a strategy built on a snapshot begins ageing the day it is signed. Where it is not true, in a market shaped mainly by demographics or infrastructure, analysis carries much further before it needs revisiting.

Getting this wrong is expensive in both directions. Treat a reacting opponent as a fixed condition and you are outmanoeuvred by something you profiled correctly a year ago. Treat a stable environment as adversarial and you pay for permanent vigilance against nothing.

It also sets the horizon in C8. Where there is an opponent, the clock is theirs.

6. Tools and Templates

The Companion relies on a small set of instruments, one for each stage of the work. They are described here and reproduced in full in the Annexures.

6.1 The Decision Basis

One page, written for the person who decides rather than the person who analysed. Not a summary of the work: the smallest thing anybody needs in order to act, and the thing that gets produced when somebody challenges the choice eighteen months later.

Field	What it carries
The decision	What is being decided, in one sentence. Not the topic, the choice
The recommendation	The position taken, and why this level rather than less or more
What bears on it	The two or three findings that change the answer, each marked settled or unsettled
Confidence and durability	How well founded it is, and how long it can be expected to hold
Decision horizon	By when this has to be decided, and what closes the window
If nothing is decided	What follows from deferral, since deferral is a decision and is rarely presented as one
Review trigger	When this gets reopened, and what would force it sooner
Who	Recommends, decides, accepts, permits, implements, reviews

One page is the constraint and the constraint is the point. Anyone who has to read forty pages to find the choice will make it without reading them. The full template is in Annexure A.

6.2 The Gate Review

Ten questions applied in order to a draft before approval. Each is a challenge somebody will eventually put to you, usually in front of other people and usually when it is too late to go away and think.

Nine of the ten test a condition from Section 3. The tenth tests expression rather than substance and is the one declared exception, because a strategy can satisfy every condition and still be written so badly nobody can act on it.

Apply them in order, and where a draft fails early go back to intent rather than adding content. A thick document is often a thin decision wearing a coat.

The review sheet, with the mapping to conditions, is in Annexure B.

6.3 The Moment Checklists

Around eighty questions across the eight moments, written to be asked out loud while the answer can still change. They are questions rather than instructions on purpose: nothing there tells you what to decide, only what you will need to have answered when somebody asks you why. The full set is in Annexure C.

6.4 The Order

The choice has to reach people who were not in the room, in a form that lets them act on it and, when asked, defend it themselves. Military orders solve exactly that problem because they were built for it.

The format is SMEAC: situation, mission, execution, administration and logistics, command and signal. It is taught across the American services and to cadets here, so a good many people in British organisations met it at seventeen. The regular British Army's sequence differs in detail, notably in putting ground before situation, and that ground paragraph is worth borrowing for anyone working with physical places.

One distinction, because borrowing the format without it is where organisations go wrong. The order is a container. What makes it work is mission command: the doctrine that somebody who understands the purpose may depart from the plan without departing from the intent. The container without the doctrine is a template, and a template will not help anyone defend anything.

Annexure D sets out what each paragraph holds and what it refuses.

6.5 The Erosion Audit

A strategy is not abandoned. It is eroded, one reasonable exception at a time, none of them recorded, until the direction nobody formally changed is no longer governing anything.

The audit is one page, run annually: what has been done that the strategy excluded, and who decided each one. The list is usually short and it is always instructive. Annexure E.

6.6 How the Tools Connect

Each instrument serves a stage, and their value is highest used together.

- The moment checklists surface what the basis will need.
- The basis records the decision and its reasoning.
- The gate review tests the basis before anyone commits to it.
- The order carries the decision to people who must act on it.
- The erosion audit checks, later, whether it still governs anything.

The chain runs from question to decision to assurance. Where one link is missing the others still work, but the reasoning stops travelling, and reasoning that does not travel has to be rebuilt by whoever needs it next.

7. Embedding

Moving from one person using this on one problem to an organisation that decides this way as a matter of course. Five stages, and they are sequential for a reason: each one is unstable without the one before it.

7.1 Adoption: One Real Decision First

Do not launch this. Take one live, genuinely difficult decision and run it through, end to end, with the basis written at the end of it.

A method introduced as a policy is judged as overhead. A method that visibly settled an argument nobody could settle is judged on the argument it settled. The second spreads and the first does not.

The candidate to pick is one where the tension is obvious to everybody and the choice has been deferred at least twice.

7.2 Governance: Deciding Where the Basis Lives

A basis nobody can find is a basis that will be rebuilt from memory.

Three questions settle this. Where is a decision basis stored, and can somebody who was not involved retrieve it in under a minute? Who is named on it, and is the permission holder named separately from the risk owner? And what forces a basis to exist at all: which decisions are significant enough that proceeding without one is a governance failure rather than a style preference?

The last question is the one with teeth. Answer it too broadly and the method becomes paperwork. Answer it too narrowly and the decisions that needed it most will be the ones that skipped it.

7.3 Assurance: Rehearsal Before Publication

Military orders work because everyone receiving one has been drilled in the format for years and shares a body of doctrine. The format is a handle on a shared pattern library. It is not the mechanism.

Hand it to an organisation with no equivalent and it becomes a template to be filled in. The purpose clause turns into decoration. The main effort quietly becomes three main efforts by the second draft. The decision rules cover only the conflicts somebody happened to think of.

The fix costs an afternoon and almost nobody does it. Before the strategy goes live, run one session where the plan is broken on purpose, and give the people who would have to respond nothing but the mission and its purpose clause.

Present something the decision rules genuinely do not cover, which takes more thought than it sounds: the tempting scenario is usually one the rules already answer. Check the scenario against each rule in turn before using it.

Whatever they decide in that room is the real strategy.

Three things usually fall out of it. A decision rule nobody had written. A purpose clause that turns out to be unusable under pressure. And the name of the person who will actually be making this call, who is frequently not the person on the organisation chart.

7.4 Capability: What People Have to Be Able to Do

Four capabilities, in rough order of how hard they are to build.

Naming a tension without resolving it in the same breath. Most people reach for the resolution immediately, and the tension disappears before it has been looked at.

Distinguishing description from explanation from estimate, in their own writing, while writing it.

Stating an exclusion in a room containing the person it costs. This is a nerve rather than a skill, and it is built by watching somebody senior do it first.

Reasoning from a purpose clause when the plan no longer fits. This is the one the rehearsal builds and nothing else does.

7.5 Maturity: What Good Looks Like Later

Maturity here is not a scoring model. It is a set of observable conditions, and the honest way to use them is to ask which are true today.

- Significant decisions have a basis, and people know where to find it
- The permission holder is named separately from the risk owner as a matter of routine
- Disagreement gets recorded rather than averaged
- Findings are marked settled or unsettled without being asked
- Exclusions survive their first serious challenge
- The annual erosion audit produces a short list rather than a long one
- Somebody three layers down can say what the strategy tells them not to do

The last one is the only test that matters, and it is the one to run first.

8. Working with an Agent

This Companion is written to be handed to an AI assistant as much as read by a person. That is a deliberate choice about where the method lives, and it comes with conditions.

8.1 Why This Matters Now

A great deal of strategy drafting is now done with an assistant, and a fluent draft is not the same thing as a decided one. A model will produce a confident, well-organised strategy on request, complete with pillars, and it will do so without a diagnosis, without a named tension and without excluding anything.

That output is exactly the document Section 1 describes: the one where everyone keeps their scope and the room stays warm.

8.2 The Conditions Constrain Any Reasoner

The eight conditions apply to a machine exactly as they apply to a person. They constrain reasoning, not the reasoner.

A model producing a direction without diagnosis, tension or exclusion has failed the same test a person would. That is a claim about the conditions rather than advice about any particular tool, which is why it belongs here and the operating advice does not: advice about tools dates in months and the constraint does not.

8.3 How to Point an Agent at This

Give it the whole Companion and tell it where you are.

- Diagnosing a problem: Sections 2 and 3, and moments M1 to M3
- Holding a draft that needs testing: Section 6.2 and moment M4
- Decided, and now writing it down: the basis, and Annexure A
- Already running and starting to drift: Section 7.5, moment M8 and Annexure E

Identifiers are stable so anything can reference anything: conditions are C1 to C8, gates G1 to G10, moments M1 to M8. Annexure B carries the mapping between gates and conditions.

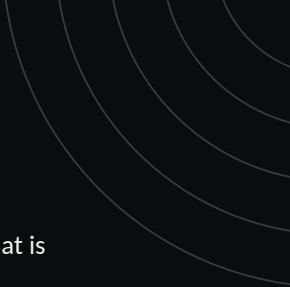
8.4 What to Tell It Not to Do

Four refusals, and they matter more for an assistant than for a person because a model will breach all four eagerly and plausibly.

It does not generate a direction. It tests one that judgement has already produced.

It does not score. There is no percentage and no maturity rating, because a strategy is not seventy per cent strategic.

It does not judge whether the organisation will accept the direction. That is a real question and a different one.



And asked to supply a strategy, the honest answer is to run the diagnosis questions and hand back what is missing.

8.5 What It Is Genuinely Good At

Three things, and they are worth using.

Holding the whole apparatus at once. No practitioner remembers eighty questions and ten gates, and an assistant that has them can ask the one that applies.

Noticing the absent thing. A model reading a draft against the conditions will reliably spot that no tension is named, which is the failure people are least able to see in their own work.

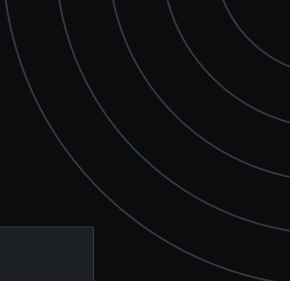
Producing the first version of the basis from a messy conversation, so the work of the room becomes a page rather than a memory. That page is then argued with, which is the point.

What it cannot do is decide, or carry the consequence, or sit in the room when the exclusion is announced.

9. Terminology

Words used precisely in this Companion, and what they are being held to mean.

Term	Meaning here
Decision basis	The stated account of why this choice and not another. The central object of this Companion
Strategy	The deliberate articulation of intent that governs how decisions are made when legitimate objectives pull in different directions
Condition	One of eight things that must be true of a choice for it to qualify as a decision rather than a preference. C1 to C8
Gate	One of ten tests applied to a draft before approval. G1 to G10. Nine test a condition; the tenth tests expression
Moment	One of eight places in the work, each with a question set. M1 to M8
Operational constraint	What is practically achievable: cost, time, capability, infrastructure, people
Legitimacy constraint	What is acceptable: law, consent, ethics, public expectation, commitments already made
Adviser	Owens the advice and never the consequence
Risk owner	Accepts the residual consequence. A named person, never a committee
Permission holder	Says whether the organisation may act at all. Frequently outside the organisation
Exclusion	What will not be pursued. The point at which direction becomes visible
Durability	How long a finding or a direction stays true
Confidence	How well founded a finding is. Independent of durability
Settled / unsettled	Whether a finding has an answer that exists, or turns on a decision nobody has taken
Decision horizon	How long before the decision must be made, set by whatever is moving against you
Main effort	The one thing resourced first when there is not enough to go round
Decision rule	A standing answer, written in advance, to a conflict that can be anticipated



Term	Meaning here
Mission command	The doctrine that somebody who understands the purpose may depart from the plan without departing from the intent
Erosion	The accumulation of reasonable, unrecorded exceptions until a direction no longer governs

Annexure A: The Decision Basis

One page. Written for the person who decides. Reproduce this as a single side.

Field	Enter
The decision	
The recommendation	
What bears on it (mark each settled or unsettled)	
Confidence and durability	
Decision horizon, and what closes the window	
If nothing is decided	
Review trigger	
Recommends	
Decides	
Accepts the consequence	
Grants permission	

Notes on completion.

The decision is a choice, not a topic. "Whether to accept the clause" is a decision. "The renewal" is a topic.

What bears on it holds two or three findings, not the assessment. Mark each one settled or unsettled, and resist the pull to mark an unsettled one settled because a settled neighbour sits next to it in the same sentence.

If nothing is decided is the field people skip and the one that most often changes the answer, because deferral is a decision and is rarely presented as one.

Annexure B: The Gate Review

Ten gates, applied in order before approval. Where a draft fails early, return to intent rather than adding content.

Gate	Pass when	Tests
G1 Context	The strategy could not be lifted into another organisation and still read as sensible	C1
G2 Diagnosis	The core problem is explicit and explains why the obvious answer has not been taken	C2, C6
G3 Tension	At least one unavoidable tension is stated and its kind is named	C3
G4 Direction	Something is ruled out, and you can name who loses by it	C4
G5 Transferability	The logic supports judgement by people who were not in the room	C4
G6 Boundary	The document governs choices without making them	C4
G7 Stress	The direction still applies when resources tighten or the opposition moves	C7
G8 Clocks	Shelf life and horizon are both stated, the horizon set by what is moving	C8
G9 Entitlement	Permission is named, and the internal and external accounts match	C5
G10 Plain statement	It can be said in five sentences without a preamble	Declared exception: expression, not substance

The automatic fail is G6. Where the document has begun choosing rather than governing choices, the boundary has gone and the rest of the review is measuring the wrong object.

The hardest to spot is G3. A paradox resolved by picking a pole reads as decisive while having discarded something the organisation cannot do without.

Where a gate has no condition behind it, it is a preference dressed as a test. Where a condition has no gate, it goes unchecked. G10 is the one deliberate exception and is named as such.

Annexure C: The Eight Moments

Questions to ask out loud, in the room, while the answer can still change.

M1. Before you start

- Is this a strategic question, or a budget question wearing a strategic coat?
- Can you name a second objective, equally legitimate, pulling against the first? If not, stop. This may be a business case, and business cases are a different and easier job.
- Is there something out there watching what we choose and adapting to it?
- Who accepts the residual consequence, by name?
- Who grants permission, and are they inside or outside the organisation?
- Who is advising, and are they a different person from those two?
- Will the risk owner convene this themselves? If not, why not, and what does that tell you?
- Can everybody in the room lose something? Who cannot?
- Has somebody set a date for this decision, and does anyone know what set it?

M2. Diagnosis

- What makes this hard here that would not be hard somewhere else?
- Could a competitor write our problem statement about themselves, word for word?
- What is the asset? Not what we value most. What the whole thing depends on.
- Who is the opposition, realistically, and what do they want?
- Which consequence actually matters if this goes wrong?
- Why has the obvious answer not already been taken?
- Who would have to lose something for it to be taken?
- For each finding: is this description, explanation or estimate?
- For each finding: settled, or unsettled and unsettleable?
- What have we assumed without a source, and is it marked as an assumption in the document itself?
- Where do two of us read this differently, and is that written down rather than averaged away?

M3. Tension and direction

- Which legitimate objectives are pulling against each other?
- Are both genuinely good things, or is one a bad habit with a defender?
- Which kind is it: puzzle, dilemma, trade-off or paradox?
- If a paradox, what would collapse it into one pole, and have we excluded that rather than choosing a side?
- Has this tension already been settled outside the organisation?
- What are we ruling out?
- Who loses by that, by name?

- Did anybody object? If nobody objected, what have we actually excluded?
- Could somebody who was not in this room apply this next March, under pressure, without ringing us?
- What may we not do, whatever we decide?
- Who grants that permission, and would they recognise our account of what we are doing?

M4. The test

- Run G1 to G10 in order, on the draft as it stands
- Where it failed early, have we gone back to intent rather than adding content?
- Is the automatic fail clear: has the document started choosing rather than governing choices?

M5. The handover

- Is the decision written as a choice, not a topic?
- Does the recommendation say why this level rather than less or more?
- Are the two or three findings that change the answer separated from the rest?
- Is each one marked settled or unsettled?
- Are confidence and durability both declared, and allowed to differ?
- Which clock is binding, ours or theirs?
- What follows from deferral, and has anybody said it out loud?
- Are all five named: recommends, decides, accepts, permits, implements?
- Does it fit on one page? Actually one page.

M6. The order

- Does the situation hold the problem and no ambition at all?
- Is the ground itself described, before anybody's intentions?
- Does the mission fit in one paragraph and survive being read aloud?
- Is there an "in order to", and does it still make sense if the task becomes impossible?
- Is there one main effort, or has it quietly become three?
- What are the decision rules for the conflicts we can already see coming?
- Is there a rule for what permission forbids?
- Does anything stop, to make room for this?
- Is the risk owner named, as a person rather than a committee?
- Is the permission holder named separately?
- Who carries the intent if the named people are not there?
- What circulates in full, and what stays with the named seats?

M7. The rehearsal

- Is there a date for this, before go-live rather than after?
- Are the people in the room the ones who would actually have to respond?
- Have they been given the mission and its purpose clause, and nothing else?
- Is the scenario genuinely outside the decision rules? Check it against each rule in turn.
- What did they decide?
- Which decision rule turned out to be missing?
- Did the purpose clause survive contact, or was it decoration?
- Who actually made the call, and is that the person on the organisation chart?

M8. The review

- What has been done since the last review that the strategy excluded?
- Who decided each one?
- For each: was it decided, or absorbed?
- Has the diagnosis changed, or only the pressure?
- Is the direction still permitted, or has something moved underneath it?
- What could happen that nobody here is planning for, and who is looking for it?
- Ask somebody three layers down who was never in the room: what does this strategy tell you not to do?
- Could they answer?

Annexure D: The Order

What each paragraph holds, and what it refuses. The container is the five-paragraph order; the mechanism is mission command.

Situation

Holds the diagnosis, conditions as they are, who else is acting on the same ground and what they are likely to do next, own position and constraints, the tension named and classified, anything already settled externally, and any disagreement recorded rather than resolved. Where the ground matters physically, describe it first, before anybody's intentions.

Refuses aspiration. This is the place for the problem, not the ambition. A situation section that reads well is usually wrong.

Mission

One paragraph. Who, what, when, where, and the purpose that follows "in order to".

Refuses everything else. If the mission needs a second paragraph, the direction has not been chosen. The purpose clause carries the weight: when circumstances change and the stated task stops making sense, people act on the purpose instead.

Execution

Doctrine puts four things here. Commander's intent, which is purpose, method and end state. Concept of operations, including where the main effort sits. Tasks, by team, each carrying the purpose behind it. And coordinating instructions, the rules governing the joints between teams, which is where delivery actually fails. A fifth belongs here and is not doctrine: decision rules, the standing answers to conflicts you can anticipate, written before the pressure arrives.

Refuses solutions the strategy did not choose. Execution sequences and resources a chosen direction. It does not get to pick a different one.

Administration and Logistics

Budget and its source. People, and what they stop doing in order to do this. Information, systems and access. Third parties. What happens to the routine work previously done by the people now assigned.

Refuses optimism. This is where a strategy is usually discovered to be undeliverable, and discovering it here costs an afternoon rather than a year. If nothing stops to make room, the organisation has added this rather than committed to it.

Command and Signal

Doctrine puts the chain of command here, including who takes over if key people are lost, and the signal plan. Succession is the element civilian organisations most often skip and the one most worth copying. To those, add the risk owner and the permission holder, named separately, then escalation, reporting, and the review trigger.

Refuses ambiguity about accountability. Where nobody is named, the strategy has no owner, and an unowned strategy gets renegotiated by whoever is under the most pressure.

One further item: circulation. A strategy governs behaviour only if people know it, and anything people know can be read by whoever competes with you. Exclusions circulate in full internally, because an exclusion nobody knows about governs nothing. The reasoning and the thresholds stay with the named seats.

Annexure E: The Erosion Audit

One page, run annually. A strategy is not abandoned. It is eroded, one reasonable exception at a time.

What was done that the strategy excluded	Who decided it	Decided or absorbed?	Recorded at the time?

Then three questions about the pattern rather than the entries.

- Has the diagnosis changed, or has only the pressure changed?
- Is the direction still permitted, or has something moved underneath it?
- What could happen that nobody here is planning for, and who is looking for it?

Do not read erosion as carelessness, because that leads to the wrong fix. The exclusion that cost somebody something at the point of decision goes on costing them every week afterwards. They go on having reasons, and each reason is good.

Judged one at a time, on its merits, every exception will be approved. That is why the audit looks at the list rather than the entries.

Contact and Continuation

This is the second Companion. One per lens of the decision-making series, and they are built to be used rather than admired.

The field tool that accompanies this one, the Strategy Decision Record, is a single page and is designed to be printed and written on. It compresses the method to five steps and the basis to seven boxes.

Corrections, disagreements and accounts of what happened when you used this are all welcome, and the disagreements are the most useful. A method that has only been tested by the person who wrote it has not been tested.

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